Brimstone and Marmalade

By Aaron Corwin

NOTE: The humor from this selection comes from the characterization and voice qualities of the characters. Go big and have fun!

NARRATOR: Mathilde didn't want a demon. She wanted a pony.

MOTHER: Ponies are expensive. How about a nice little demon instead?

MATHILDE: *(stamping her foot)* I don't want a demon! Demons are ugly and creepy and they smell bad!

FATHER: We'll see.

MATHILDE: *(to audience)* When a grown-up said "we'll see," it really meant "never." Peter Voorhees brought his demon to school. It was scaly and slobbery, not sleek and pretty like a pony. How could anyone think that a demon was better?

INTRODUCTION

When I was little, I desperately wanted a pot-belly pig – But my parents in all of their wisdom gifted me with BURBLES – the goldfish. BURBLES didn't last very long, and I remember hosting my own little funeral service as we flushed him to his watery resting place.

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BURBLES was followed by a succession of other small creatures – 4 more fish, a hamster, and a bunny. At least I wasn't condemned to own a pet rock!

In this fantasy selection, Mathilde doesn't get the pony she wants; but a miniature demon named Ix'Thor. Take that, BURBLES.

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NARRATOR: The day before Mathilde's birthday in September . . .

PRINCIPAL: Mathilde, your parents called. Your grandmother is picking you up.

MATHILDE: Nana's here for my birthday? Nana always brought presents. (to Nana) Nana!

NANA: Look at you! My little Matty-Patty's all grown up!

MATHILDE: *(giggling)* Where are we going?

NANA: You didn't think I'd come all this way and not bring you a present, did you? The sort of present you'd better pick out for yourself!

NARRATOR: Mathilde could scarcely believe it. After all this waiting, she was finally going to get a pony of her very own. But when the car stopped, it was in front of a store covered in steel plates and the air smelled just a little bit like rotten eggs. It was very dark inside.

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MATHILDE: This isn't a pony store! This is a demon store! I don't want a demon! I want a pony!

NANA: When I was a girl, we had a Belgian Muncher on the farm. Smart as a whip if you train 'em right. You know the best thing about demons? They're great for convincing parents that little girls are responsible enough to take care of a pony. If you prove you can take care of a demon. . . then we can see about that pony. *(Nana and Mathilde enter the store)*

SHOP KEEPER: Well, hello there! Are you here for a new demon?

NANA: Yes. It's her birthday.

SHOP KEEPER: *(to Mathilde)* I see! What sort of demon were you looking for?

MATHILDE: The kind with the pretty eyes and the long, shiny mane!

NANA: *(sighing heavily)* That's a pony, dear.

MATHILDE: Well, that's what I want!

SHOP KEEPER: Oh, I think I have just the one for you. *(he pulls out a small glass cage)*

NARRATOR: The demon inside didn't have a long, shiny mane. It didn't have any hair at all, just a tiny, black

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hooded robe. Its eyes were two red stars that twinkled in the darkness of its hood like Christmas lights.

SHOP KEEPER: He's a Miniature Dark Lord.

NANA: *(shaking her head)* A Dark Lord? I thought they had great big horns!

SHOP KEEPER: Normally. But this poor little guy was born without any. All the other Dark Lords rejected him.

MATHILDE: *(feeling a connection with rejection)* What's your name?

IX'THOR: *(raising his arms over his head)* I AM IX'THOR, MASTER OF THE VENOMOUS PITS OF KARTHOOM! BOW BEFORE YOUR MASTER!

SHOP KEEPER: How about that! He told you his name first thing. He must really like you.

MATHILDE: *(pouting)* Well, I don't like him . . . *(IX'THOR is deflated, lowers his arms and hangs his head)* But I guess he'll do.

NARRATOR: Mathilde had a hard time sleeping that night. Her thoughts kept drifting toward the pony she would have someday. How long would she have to take care of a stupid demon, anyway?

MATHILDE: *(sleeping . . . she snores lightly)*

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IX'THOR: *(pokes MATHILDE on the chin, she swats him away, but he continues to poke)*

MATHILDE: *(awakens with a start)*

IX'THOR: KNEEL BEFOR YOUR MASTER, MORTAL!

MATHILDE: Aaaaaah! Mom! *(IX'THOR squeals and quickly hides)*

MOTHER: How did he get out of his cage? *(looks around the room for the demon)*

MATHILDE: *(also looking, she sees a dark shape dart under her bed and grabs a flashlight)* He's right here! *(she reaches under the bed and grabs his little body)* I've got him!

IX'THOR: *(slashing has her hand with his claws)*

MATHILDE: EEEEEEE! *(abruptly drops him, crying)* I hate demons! I want a pony!

MOTHER: Oh, sweetie. It's just a tiny little cut. He was just scared, that's all. You have to be careful with animals. When they're scared they lash out. They don't know any better.

MATHILDE: *(belligerently)* I don't want him in my room!

NANA: *(clearly disappointed)* I'm sorry. I'll take him back to the store tomorrow.

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MATHILDE: *(she remembers her pony and backpedals)* Wait! I didn't mean it. He can stay.

MOTHER: This is your last chance. If you say you don't want him one more time, we'll give him to someone who does.

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NARRATOR: [The next day – Mathilde's Birthday]

MATHILDE: *(excited)* There was cake! Chocolate with white frosting and candy sprinkles. And presents! A camera and a unicycle and *(sadly)* eleven different kinds of **TOY** ponies. *(to the kids at the party)* I did get another present . . . You want to see him? *(she leads them to her bedroom)* You have to turn the lights down. *(as she dims the lights)* He doesn't like light.

BECKY: It's not a snake is it?

MATHILDE: Shhh! It's not a snake. *(She lifts the cover from the cage)*

IX'THOR: WELCOME TO MY DOMAIN. FOOLS! DID YOU THINK YOU COULD DEFEAT ME?

ROBBY: Wow! That's cool!

MATHILDE: *(with a real smile of pride)* He's a Dark Lord.

ROBBY: Does he do any tricks?

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IX'THOR: BOW BEFORE ME!

MATHILDE: You shouldn't actually bow. That just encourages him.

BECKY: It's just a demon. What good is a demon who doesn't even do anything? I bet he bites.

IX'THOR: FOOLISH MORTALS. NOW BEHOLD MY TRUE POWER! *(he waves his arms and emits a bust of fire from his hands)*

ROBBY: WOW! You said he didn't do any tricks!

IX'THOR: GIVE ME YOUR SOUL AND I WILL GRANT YOU LIMITLESS POWER.

MATHILDE: Mom says I can't have limitless power until I'm older. But you can have a grub soul.

NARRATOR: [Mathilde takes out] a small, softly glowing ball, about the size of a pea from the big plastic bag Nana had bought. The bag said things like "Nutritionally Balanced" and "Now with extra innocence for a health glow!"

IX'THOR: EXCELLENT *(racing to the side of the cage, he stands with his arms outstretched)* IX'THOR ACCEPTS YOUR SACRIFICE. *(he devours the pellet)* NUM NUM NUM!

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NARRATOR: [Soon it was Halloween] A witch came to the house with a black pointy had, a broomstick, green skin and a big, warty nose.

MATHILDE: Nana!

NANA: *(in a big witchy voice)* Happy Halloween! Eee-hee-he-hee! How's my little angel?

MATHILDE: I'm not an angel *(raises the hood to her robe and speaks in an Ix'Thor voice)* I'm a Dark Lord. Bow before me, mortals!

NANA: *(feigning fright)* Oh, my! I think I felt the earth tremble for a moment.

MATHILDE: *(mimicking IX'THOR)* Excellent. It is just as I have foretold. *(She picks up a traveling crystal ball and holds it up)* Ix'thor's coming with us! He says fear keeps the peasants in line.

NANA: Mathilde . . . you know not everything Ixthor says is a good idea, right?

MATHILDE: *(rolling her eyes)* Well, duh!

IX'THOR: MWA HA HA! NOTHING CAN STOP US NOW!

MATHILDE: *(mimicking IX'THOR)* I'll take my revenge when I rule the world. Mwa ha ha.

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(Mathilde starts to walk toward the street, trips and falls forward. The crystal ball holding Ix'Thor launches from her hand and tumbles through the air into the street – there is the sound of squealing brakes and then shattering glass)

MATHILDE: No! *(she races to Ix'thor)* Ix'thor! Please!

IX'THOR: THIS . . . CANNOT . . . BE. I AM IN . . . VINCIBLE . . .

******* At the demon store *******

NARRATOR: [The family rushes Ix'thor to the demon store, hoping the shop owner can save him]

FATHER: Demons are pretty strong, right? Almost impossible to kill?

SHOP KEEPER: Dark Lords are weaker in direct sunlight. Much weaker. I did all I could.

MATHILDE: *(crying)*

MOTHER: Oh, sweetie. It wasn't your fault. There was nothing anyone could have done. *(more sobbing from Mathilde)* Father and I were talking to Nana. If you still want one . .

MATHILDE: *(defiantly)* I don't want a pony! I want Ix'thor. But I can't have him back, can I?

MOTHER: No, I'm sorry.

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MATHILDE: Then . . . can I get a pony with glowing red eyes and crush the skulls of my enemies beneath his flaming hooves?

MOTHER: *(laughing)* One with glowing eyes!

MATHILDE: *(in her best Ix'thor voice)* Excellent! It is just as I have foretold . . .

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